



Dr. Sanjay Agarwal

The Infrastructure Futurist

Dr. Sanjay Agarwal didn't just build India's highways—he pioneered the execution models that will define the next generation of nation-building.

When Dr. Sanjay Agarwal orchestrated India's first large-scale Build-Operate-Transfer highway project in 2002, completing a 150-kilometer four-lane BoT Toll stretch on NH5/NH9 in a record two years, he wasn't just delivering infrastructure—he was proving that Indian companies could execute at global standards. Nearly four decades later, as he transitions from execution to mentorship through SA Associates, the question isn't what he's built, but what his vision will enable others to create.

The trajectory reveals a pattern: Agarwal anticipates infrastructure trends rather than following them. In 1999, when India launched its highway revolution through the Golden Quadrilateral, IJM Corporation appointed him to lead its Indian infrastructure initiatives. While competitors were familiar with BoT frameworks, Agarwal was pioneering design, monitoring and tolling systems that would become industry standards..

"Agarwal observes that people often think of infrastructure as concrete and steel. In reality, it is about relationships. Every kilometre involves hundreds of negotiations and thousands of compromises. Engineering is

straightforward while the human dimension is complex.

His understanding of infrastructure as a socio-technical system, not merely an engineering challenge, distinguishes visionary CEOs from operational managers. As COO and Director of IJM India Infrastructure, he transformed project execution. The incorporation of drone technology for real-time monitoring and Building Information Modelling demonstrated his recognition that India's infrastructure leap would require a digital transformation of the entire construction ecosystem.

In May 2021, his team set a national record by laying 25.54 lane kilometers in just 17.45 hours on the Solapur-Bijapur section of Highway 13. The achievement demonstrated that Indian infrastructure could achieve manufacturing-grade process precision at civil engineering scale.

The Solapur-Vijayapura project, one of NHAI's largest contracts, was completed ahead of schedule despite pandemic challenges. When nearly 2,000 workers were stranded at project sites during lockdowns, Agarwal's response revealed leadership philosophy: "They couldn't move anywhere so we looked after them

ourselves. That built a lot of respect."

Through SA Associates, Agarwal is architecting his most ambitious project: transferring 38 years of pattern recognition, stakeholder navigation and crisis management to India's next generation of infrastructure leaders. "Experience alone does not create leaders. Someone must impart knowledge that textbooks do not cover," he explains.

Recognition has followed: Honorary Doctorate in Construction Science from University of De Milano, FLUXX Conference Middle East Hall of Fame (Doha 2025), India's Greatest Brands & Leaders award (Dubai 2023). But Agarwal's most significant contribution may be ahead: as India contemplates trillion-dollar infrastructure investments, the execution models and institutional knowledge he's systematising through SA Associates could determine whether ambition translates into reality.

"I tell aspiring leaders: failures are stepping stones. Have courage to start again. Ethics and hard work are the foundation. Technical brilliance without integrity builds nothing lasting."

For a CEO who has delivered over 5,000 lane kilometres, the next chapter focuses on multiplying impact—not through the creation of new infrastructure but by enabling hundreds of leaders to build better. In the realm of infrastructure, this is how visionaries create legacy: by making excellence replicable.